



One to keep: Shahbaz Ahmed shows his *Sportstar* magazine poster to teammates during a break in practice before the final Test against India in Chennai on March 26, 1998. THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY

with young players, but the system must first improve.

Is skillset making the difference between Indian and Pakistani players?

Skillset is not the main difference between Indian and Pakistani players; rather, it is the system that develops them for high-performance hockey. The key factor is how well players execute game plans and fulfil their roles within the team's structure—essentially, their game intelligence.

Indian players tend to utilise their skills more effectively, adapting to the playing conditions and match situations with greater precision.

You praised the Hockey India League. Should the PHF consider launching a similar tournament?

Absolutely. A premier hockey league would provide young players with financial support and exposure.

Beyond that, our national team must tour abroad for 3-4 months every year, ensuring each player competes in at least 30 high-quality matches.

That's the only way to groom

talent and gain international experience.

You had a long and successful career. What's your most cherished memory?

I played for Pakistan for 18 years, one of the longest-serving members of the team. Some moments will always stay with me. In 1987, when I played the Indira Gandhi Gold Cup in India, massive crowds turned up to support us. Fans carried banners calling me 'Superman' and chanted my name. That was unforgettable.

Another moment was the 1994 World Cup final in Sydney. Fans from New Zealand and Australia approached me, saying, "You're the only one who truly knows how to play hockey." Such encouragement and respect kept us going.

Top of the world: Pakistan captain Shahbaz Ahmed poses with the World Cup after his team's tie-breaker win over the Netherlands in the 1994 Hockey World Cup final in Sydney on December 4. THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY

